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Great Allegheny Passage trail nears finish

By Bob Karlovits

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A crucial and complicated stretch of a trail connecting Pittsburgh with Washington, D.C., opens this morning, but amid the celebration of accomplishment is a nod to reality.

Trail advocates once hoped to have the whole Great Allegheny Passage open by Nov. 11, but "we are just too close to expect 11/11," said Linda McKenna Boxx, executive director of the Allegheny Trail Alliance. A two-mile stretch near Sandcastle Waterpark remains unfinished.

The three-mile section that opens today, from an industrial park in Duquesne to the fringes of The Waterfront shopping area in Munhall, runs across seven active rail lines, skirts a hillside ledge below Kennywood Park and sidesteps property that planners could not acquire.

It puts the passage -- used by 750,000 people last year, according to Boxx -- within two miles of connecting Pittsburgh and Cumberland, Md., where the trail links to the C&O Canal Trail, which goes to Washington, D.C.

The section officially opens at a 10 a.m. ceremony at the base of the rail crossing bridge in Whitaker. For the past several weeks, trail officials have allowed riders who happened across the trail to test it.

The stretch cost about \$6 million for design and construction, said Jack Paulik, project manager for Regional Trail Corp. Half of that was for two bridges, which are 127 and 170 feet long, made of reddish Corten steel and decked with synthetic wood planking.

Of the remaining two miles needed to complete the trail, only one requires dramatic work, Boxx and Paulik said. The other involves basically the creation of a bike lane on a roadway through the Waterfront.

West of that, though, some light posts must be moved to provide wider access near Sandcastle. Retaining walls and other safety installations need to be built on a stretch through Keystone Iron and Metal just before the trail meets an existing one in Baldwin Township, Paulik said.

Those final miles should cost about \$3.1 million. Boxx said the group has raised about \$1 million and is hoping for the release of a \$750,000 grant that state Sen. Jay Costa, D-Allegheny County, added to the capital budget.

Raising the rest of the money will delay work enough to prevent an 11/11 completion, which had been an informal target, Boxx said. The completion now is expected in spring 2012.

Finishing the most recent section is "awesome," she said, considering all of the complications involved. It meant dealing with the owners of 13 pieces of property and several municipalities, enlisting the cooperation of the Norfolk Southern and Union railroads and facing unexpected problems.

In one stretch near Duquesne, Paulik said, workers discovered they were at a drainage area and had to install storm drains. They also found they were near a fiber-optic media cable, which meant moving the trail a few inches.

Unlike the rest of the trail, which is surfaced in crushed limestone, this portion is topped with asphalt. Boxx, Paulik and other planners see this stretch being used by commuters and other types of day users.

"I can see people riding from the Duquesne industrial park to the Waterfront for lunch," Boxx said.

Bob Karlovits can be reached at bkarlovits@tribweb.com or 412-320-7852.

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